

Getting Around Tokyo

Tokyo's rail network is the fastest way to get around the city. Buy a rechargeable IC card such as Suica or Pasma at any station kiosk or vending machine and tap in and out of JR, Tokyo Metro, and most bus lines without buying individual tickets. The Yamanote Line loops through the major hubs — Shinjuku, Shibuya, Ueno, and Tokyo Station — so it is the line most first-time visitors rely on. Trains stop running shortly after midnight, so plan your last connection carefully or budget for a taxi back to your hotel.

Best Neighborhoods to Stay

Shinjuku is a good base for first-time visitors: it has excellent rail connections, a huge range of hotels at every price point, and is walking distance from the Golden Gai bar district and Omoide Yokocho food alleys. Shibuya suits travelers who want nightlife and shopping close by. Asakusa is quieter and more traditional, with the Senso-ji temple area and easy access to the Tokyo Skytree, and tends to have better value for longer stays.